GRADE 4

Curriculum Book

Businesses need a simple plan

Five questions, one page, one plan. Make the idea move.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Grade 4 - Curriculum Book

Five questions, one page, one plan. Make the idea move. This book is part of the Cash to Company K-12 program - a financial literacy and entrepreneurship curriculum aligned to Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, and CASEL standards.

This guide is for the teacher who picks up Grade 4 of the program for the first time. *You don't need to be an entrepreneur. You don't need to be a math specialist. You need to enforce one norm — thinking has to be specific — and keep the four-quarter rhythm working. The lesson plans, rubrics, and Cash videos do most of the heavy lifting. Your highest-leverage move is the question "How do you know?" — asked every time a student says something vague.*

Five answers, one page

The whole plan fits on one sheet of paper.

1. The shape of the year

"A plan is just five honest answers in a row. Start with one."

- CASH, GRADE 4

Grade 4 is a bridge year between Grade 3 (where students name ideas from skills/hobbies/needs) and Grade 5 (where pricing-with-margin and Market Day arrive). The year theme is *Businesses need a simple plan*. The Capstone is the One-Page Plan — a single sheet, completed and revised across the year, defended in front of a small panel in Week 36.

The four units map to the four quarters:

- **Unit 1 (Weeks 1–8) — Read a real business.** Students profile a real local business in 3–5 sentences. They draft a "Capstone Topic" — the kind of business they'll plan all year.
- **Unit 2 (Weeks 9–18) — The Reality Check.** Students run their idea through the 5-question Reality Check: Who buys? How much? How many? What does it cost me? What's left? They write a one-sentence customer statement.
- **Unit 3 (Weeks 19–28) — The $50 Plan.** Students build a one-page event budget under a $50 cap with at least 4 categories. They learn three rules for a kid-run business and pick the most important one with a reason.
- **Unit 4 (Weeks 29–36) — The One-Page Plan defense.** Students write the One-Page Plan, revise it, mark three changes with reasons, and defend the final version in 4 minutes to a small panel.

Each unit ends with a Capstone Checkpoint. Each Checkpoint is graded with a Rubric Bank rubric, simplified for the 3–5 band as noted in the Curriculum Book.

2. Weekly rhythm (Model A — standalone weekly course, 60–90 min/week)

> **TRY THIS**
>
> ### One question, five people
>
> Pick the customer question from your one-page plan. Ask five real people in one day. Write each answer in one sentence.

A typical week:

DAY	WHAT HAPPENS
Monday (15 min)	Cash video segment (when one is scheduled) + Capstone Journal opener + 1–2 student share.
Wednesday (45–60 min)	The long block. Mini-lesson + Capstone work + 5-min close. Confer with 4–5 students.
Friday (15–20 min)	Showcase + Stuck. 3 students share progress; 1 shares a blocker; class brainstorms one idea per blocker.

If you're running Model B (embedded), use the 30–45 minutes/week pattern in the Implementation Guide. The lesson plans assume the full Wednesday block. They shorten cleanly — drop the "Engage" hook to 3 minutes and stretch the "Apply" out across two short sessions.

3. Pacing — what's adjustable and what isn't

WORDS TO KNOW

Plan
Five honest answers about how a business works.

Customer
The exact person you can name and describe.

Offer
What the customer gets, in plain words.

Pricing
What the customer pays, and why that number.

Test
The smallest real thing you can do to see if the plan works.

Don't compromise on:

- The four Capstone Checkpoints (Weeks 8, 18, 28, 36). These are the year's spine.
- The 5-Question Reality Check in Unit 2. It is the math foundation for Grade 5.
- The $50 budget cap in Unit 3. The cap forces the trade-off; without it the lesson is empty.
- The Defense in Week 36. Even with two students it's worth running with a small panel.

You can flex on:

- The exact Cash videos shown. If your tech doesn't allow video, read the printed transcripts aloud — they read well.
- Which lessons in the lesson plans book you anchor each unit on. The 10 sampled lessons cover the year, but the unit work continues between them.

- Which classroom event students budget in Unit 3 (Game Day, Craft Afternoon, Read-Aloud Day). Pick what matches your school.
- The Capstone topic each student picks. The list of "Capstone-friendly" categories in Activity 1.3 is a guide, not a fence. Many students invent.

4. Classroom routines that pay off

> **MATH MOMENT**
>
> **How many a week?**
>
> If you sold 3 a day for 5 days, how many is that? If each one costs $2 to make and sells for $5, what's left?

The Confer Loop

The single highest-leverage move in the year is the 2–3 minute confer. While most students work, you sit beside one student and read what they wrote. You ask one sharpening question. You move on.

Sample sharpening questions, by unit:

- **Unit 1:** "*Could you point to a customer in this profile? Who, exactly?*"
- **Unit 2:** "*How did you get to that number? Could you actually serve that many in a Saturday?*"
- **Unit 3:** "*Where did you first go over $50? What did you cut, and why?*"
- **Unit 4:** "*Which of your three changes mattered most? Tell me why in one sentence.*"

You will get to 4–6 students per Wednesday. By Week 18, you'll have conferred with every student multiple times. They will start asking each other the questions you've been asking them.

The Vocabulary Spine

Each student keeps a Vocabulary Spine in the back of the Capstone Journal (Activity Book has a template). Each new term gets a one-line definition in the student's own words. By Week 28, the Spine has ~18 entries. Reference it weekly. Revoice ("In your Spine, what's the difference between *cost* and *price*?") rather than quizzing.

The Showcase + Stuck

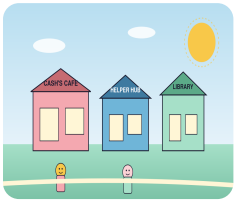
Every Friday, three students share progress and one student shares a blocker. The class brainstorms one possible solution per blocker (no more than 30 seconds each). This routine teaches two things at once: that real work has stuck moments, and that other people's ideas often unstick yours.

Don't let Showcase + Stuck become "look what I made!" That's a finished-work celebration. You want progress + stuck. Coach the framing.

5. Grading and reporting

CASH ASKS

"*What did they actually say? Tell me one real sentence.*"



PEOPLE YOU CAN ASK

Five real answers

Read each plan answer to a different person. Write what they say back, exactly. That's data.

What to grade

- The four Capstone Checkpoints (Weeks 8, 18, 28, 36) — graded on the Rubric Bank rubrics, simplified for the 3–5 band.

- A short reflection memo per unit — graded on Reflection Writing rubric (3–5 setting).
- Participation in weekly meetings + Showcase + Stuck — narrative comment, not a number.

What not to grade

- Capstone Journal entries (formative — read for understanding, not a number).
- Vocabulary Spine (formative).
- Cash-video reflections (holistic, low-stakes).

Suggested weighting (for schools that issue letter grades)

- Capstone Checkpoints (4 total): 60% of grade.
- Final Capstone Defense (Week 36): 20%.
- Reflection memos + participation + journal: 20%.

For schools that don't issue traditional grades, the four checkpoint rubrics + the Final Defense rubric give a portfolio-quality narrative for parents.

6. The Cash voice in your classroom

FAMILY TALK

Five honest answers

Read your one-page plan to a family member. Ask: 'Which answer sounds the least real to you, and why?' Listen, don't defend.

Cash's voice in 3–5 is short, concrete, and never hyped. The teacher's voice doesn't have to mimic Cash's, but it should rhyme.

Avoid:

- "*Awesome job!*" / "*Amazing!*" — Cash never flatters. Replace with "*Okay, that's specific. What's the evidence?*"

- "*You can be anything you want!*" — Cash never promises wealth or success. Replace with "*You'll be a clearer thinker about money no matter what.*"
- "*You should think about your family's money.*" — Cash never asks about family money. Replace with "*For a sample customer, what would the price be?*"

Use:

- "*How do you know?*"
- "*Which kids? Which Tuesday?*"
- "*What's one number you could check?*"
- "*Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal.*"

The line that earns a year: "*That's a guess. What would make it real?*"

7. FAQ — common teacher questions

CASH ASKS

"*Five ideas beats one idea. Pick the most real-sounding one.*"

"What if a student finishes Unit 1 without a Capstone Topic?"

That's fine. The Week 9 pivot window exists for exactly this. Coach gently. "*What's something you're good at? What's something you wish someone would fix?*" By Week 12 they'll have one.

"What if a student picks a Capstone idea that's clearly impractical (a video game company, a movie studio)?"

Allow it, but anchor with the Reality Check. The math will reveal what's possible. A student who runs the 5 questions on a "video game studio" idea and lands on *I'd need 200 customers a week and I don't know any* has done the work.

"What if students want to actually run their business, not just plan it?"

Encourage it. The lesson plans support both. A student who actually sells lemonade (with adult permission, with hand-washing, with honest claims) will have the richest Unit 4 reflection.

"What if a student's $50 budget keeps coming out at $63?"

The cap is the lesson. If they come in at $63, they have to cut. *That's* the moment. Don't bail them out. Walk them through *which subtotal is biggest? What can you do without?*

"What if a student says they don't want a customer who's specific — they want everyone to like them?"

This is a developmental moment. Coach: "*Most successful businesses serve some people very well. They don't serve everyone. Who's your first one? The one who'd pay you on Saturday?*" Validate the impulse, redirect toward specificity.

"What if a student wants to interview customers (and we never asked them to)?"

Encourage. Hand them a sentence-frame interview script (*Tell me about the last time you _____. What was annoying about it?*) and let them do 1–2 interviews. This previews Grade 7 work and sharpens their Capstone fast.

"How do I keep momentum across 36 weeks without burning out?"

Two moves help most:

1. **The Vocabulary Spine** keeps work compounding without re-explaining.
2. **The Showcase + Stuck** every Friday keeps the work social and visible.

Most importantly: trust the four-checkpoint rhythm. Each unit ends with a real artifact and a real grade. The year doesn't drift if those four moments hold.

8. Common pitfalls

Pitfall: Letting "kids" or "everyone" stand as a customer

The single most common Grade 4 trap. A student writes "*this is for kids*" and you let it slide. By Unit 3 the customer is still vague and the math doesn't work because there's no real customer to anchor the price. Catch this in Week 5–8. Push for one demographic + one moment + one need.

Pitfall: Phantom "home" supplies

A student writes "*my cost is $0 because my mom buys the supplies.*" The math of the business doesn't care who pays. Coach: "*If you ran this for real, you'd buy them. What would they cost?*"

Pitfall: Cheerleader feedback

A teacher who says "*amazing!*" to every Capstone draft is undermining the year. Cash never says amazing. Specific feedback ("*What's the cost per customer?*") beats enthusiasm every time. Practice scripts:

- Instead of "*Great work!*" → "*Okay, that's specific. What's the evidence?*"
- Instead of "*You're so creative!*" → "*That's a real idea. Who's the first customer?*"
- Instead of "*This is wonderful!*" → "*You did the math. What does it tell you?*"

Pitfall: Asking about family money

The most common slip in financial education. Even well-meaning prompts ("How does your family budget?") wound students from food-insecure or unbanked families. Default to hypothetical scenarios. The classroom-event budget framing is non-negotiable. Re-read the Sensitivity section in the Curriculum Book before designing any new activity.

Pitfall: Running the Defense as a Shark Tank

The Capstones are about evidence and revision, not about which kid had the most impressive idea. Coach panel members AWAY from "would you invest?" framing and TOWARD "what did you learn?"

Pitfall: Skipping the Cash videos

The Cash videos are concept anchors. Skipping them removes the connective tissue between units. If you can't play them, read transcripts aloud — but include them.

9. Calibration before the first Checkpoint

CASH SAYS

"*First tries get something wrong. The fix is what makes you a real entrepreneur.*"

Before grading the Real-Business Profile (Week 8), do this once:

1. Pick 3 sample profiles (your own writing, from previous students with permission, or instructor exemplars).
2. Score each one independently against the simplified Rubric 1 (Customer clarity, Value proposition, Financial logic, Communication).

3. Compare scores. If scores differ by more than 1 on any criterion, discuss why and recalibrate.
4. Record the "anchor 3" — the score-of-3 paper for each criterion. Use it as your reference for the rest of the year.

If you're the only Grade 4 teacher, do this exercise with the Grade 5 teacher, or with anyone willing to read the rubric. The point is to calibrate before grading 25 papers, not after.

10. Connecting to other grades

From Grade 3

Students arrive having named business ideas from skills/hobbies/needs and computed simple cost/revenue/profit on a lemonade-stand scenario. They've drawn a logo. The Skills + Hobbies + Needs web from Grade 3 is fair game as Day 1 idea fuel.

Toward Grade 5

Strong Grade 4 work — a sharp customer statement, a clean budget, a plan that revised three times — sets students up to thrive in Grade 5's pricing-with-margin and Market Day. The Grade 5 teacher should review the Capstone Journals in late spring. 30 minutes scanning ten journals tells you where the cohort is.

11. The one-page reminder

If you read nothing else, remember:

- **Spine question:** *You picked this idea. How do you know somebody actually wants it?*
- **Cash voice:** specific, calm, no hype, never asks about family money.
- **Four Checkpoints, four rubrics, one Capstone.**

- **Confer 2–3 minutes per student per week. Ask one sharpening question.**
- **A plan is thinking written down. The point is to make thinking visible enough to fix.**

You have everything you need. The students will surprise you. Let them.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Differentiation deep moves (Grade 4)

Advanced learners — three named extensions

1. **Two-budget comparison.** A student who finishes the $50 budget fast: write a second version at $35 (a more constrained version). Compare. "*What did you cut, and why?*" Builds tradeoff thinking.
2. **Customer statement variations.** Take one idea and write three customer statements, each for a different customer. "*How does the product change for each?*" Seeds Grade 7 segmentation.
3. **Reading a real local plan.** Bring in a real plan (a school budget, a fundraiser proposal, a parent's small-business one-pager — with permission). The student reads and identifies the parts.

ELL deep moves

- **Pre-translated category names.** *Cost, revenue, profit, customer, plan, idea* — print on a card with the student's home-language equivalent.
- **Pair on the customer statement.** The 1-sentence format is harder for ELL. Pair with a strong English partner for the first attempt; independent for the second.
- **Allow the budget in two languages.** Numbers are universal; the labels can be bilingual.

IEP/504 deep moves

- **Pre-printed budget template with 4 category boxes.** Removes blank-page paralysis.
- **Calculator allowed.** The decision-making is the goal, not the arithmetic.
- **Chunked Reality Check.** The 5-question Reality Check is too long for some students in one sitting. Allow over 2 days, one section per day.

Sensitivity tightening for Grade 4

Verify all sample budgets use phrasings like "for a hypothetical school event" rather than "for our family's home." If a student volunteers home-budget information, listen briefly, validate, route to counselor if it surfaces something heavy. Never assign homework that requires the student to ask family members about money.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

Cash never says: "Amazing!" / "Awesome!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Anyone can be a millionaire" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" / "Just believe" / "Believe in yourself" (as substitute for evidence) / "If you can dream it, you can do it" / "Side hustle" (use "side venture") / wealth-flexing language / anything implying wealth is mindset/hustle / anything implying low-income/ unbanked families are at fault.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "What did they actually say?" / "Whats the evidence?" / "What would have to be true for you to be right?" / "Whats one thing youd change?"

Teacher mirror: Replace "great job!" with "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?"

Cashs three signature physical moves: (1) **Notebook Tilt** — turning the clipboard toward camera before reading a quote; (2) **Two-Finger Tap** — tapping a number twice when emphasizing it; (3) **Slow Lean** — leaning toward camera before a contrarian truth.

FROM CASH

A plan is five honest answers

Who is it for? What is it? Why now? How much? How will I know it worked? Five lines. One page. Done.

KEEP IT REAL

Real customers. Real money. Real lessons.

Every page in this book points back to one habit: ask a real person, listen to the real answer, count the real numbers. The rest is decoration.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

What Grade 4 hits

This curriculum book aligns to the following K-12 standards. See the *Master Standards Alignment Map* for the full grade-band crosswalk.

Jump$tart 3-5
Income - earning, planning, and tradeoffs.

CEE NS5
Roles of producers, consumers, and decisions.

CCSS-MATH 4.OA
Operations and algebraic thinking - model word problems.

CCSS-ELA W.4.2
Write to inform and explain - one-page plan.

CASEL Responsible Decision-Making
Identify problems, analyze situations.

C3 D2.Eco.2.3-5
Identify positive and negative incentives.

FROM CASH

One last thing

"*A plan is just five honest answers in a row. Start with one.*"

- CASH, GRADE 4

A plan is just five honest answers in a row. Start with one. — Cash

Cash to Company • Grade 4 • Curriculum Book